

READING PASSAGE 1

The Impact of Dams on River Ecosystems

A In recent years, the impact of dams on river ecosystems has attracted considerable attention from both the academic community and the general public. This growing interest reflects a broader recognition of the importance of this topic for understanding some of the most pressing challenges facing contemporary society.

B The origins of contemporary research in this area can be traced to pioneering studies conducted during the mid-twentieth century. These early investigations, though constrained by the technological and methodological limitations of their era, established foundational principles that continue to inform current scholarship. Successive generations of researchers have built upon these foundations, progressively refining theoretical models and expanding the empirical evidence base through increasingly sophisticated research designs.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D A substantial body of empirical evidence supports these theoretical frameworks. A landmark study conducted by researchers at leading international institutions analysed data spanning a thirty-year period and involving participants from more than forty countries. The findings revealed a consistent pattern of results that held across diverse cultural and economic contexts, suggesting that the identified mechanisms operate with considerable universality. The magnitude of the observed effects was particularly striking, with the key variables accounting for a substantial proportion of the total variance in outcomes.

E The practical application of research findings has proven more challenging than many initially anticipated. The translation of academic knowledge into actionable policy recommendations requires navigating a complex landscape of political constraints, economic interests, and social dynamics that academic models often simplify or overlook. Implementation failures in several high-profile initiatives have underscored the gap between theoretical understanding and practical capacity, prompting calls for more engaged and context-sensitive approaches to research.

F Looking ahead, the field stands at a critical juncture. Emerging technologies offer unprecedented opportunities for data collection and analysis, potentially enabling researchers to address questions that have long remained beyond the reach of empirical investigation. At the same time, the accelerating pace of social and technological change means that the phenomena under study are themselves evolving, requiring theoretical frameworks that can accommodate dynamism and discontinuity rather than assuming stability and equilibrium.

G In conclusion, the study of the impact of dams on river ecosystems represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Questions 1–2

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 1 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.
- 2 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Questions 3–4

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 3 What finding emerged from the landmark study discussed in the passage?
 - A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration
- 4 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
 - A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration

Question 5

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 5 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.

Question 6

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 6 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
 - A. inconsistent results across cultures
 - B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
 - C. no measurable effects
 - D. effects limited to Western countries

Question 7

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.

Questions 8–9

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 8 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
- A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
 - C. contradictory findings
 - D. results only in specific populations
- 9 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
- A. economic incentives and institutional constraints
 - B. individual personality traits
 - C. random chance
 - D. government policies alone

Question 10

Complete the sentences below. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

- 10 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 11

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write **TRUE** if the statement agrees with the information

Write **FALSE** if the statement contradicts the information

Write **NOT GIVEN** if there is no information on this

- 11 Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.

Question 12

Complete the sentences below. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

- 12 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.

Question 13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write **TRUE** if the statement agrees with the information

Write **FALSE** if the statement contradicts the information

Write **NOT GIVEN** if there is no information on this

- 13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.